

Connecting with the heart of India

>>The world looks at emerging markets to sustain growth, yet the single biggest challenge faced by businesses in India, is being able to tap into the rural market. > by Vishwanath Alluri

According to the 2011 Census of India, 68.84 per cent of our population resides in rural India. What this means is that a little over two thirds of our nation doesn't have access to technology as consumed in urban metros. To promote rural development, the government in the recently announced budget has declared a 46 per cent increase in rural development funds.

The major part of our rural population is unexplored by Indian companies, but the trend seems to be changing with time. Companies are now realising the importance of reaching out to the rural population and creating awareness about their offerings.

One of the major concerns that companies face today is to identify an ideal way to reach out to rural customers. Mobile as a medium is very seriously being considered by various enterprises to effectively reach out to their respective customers.

According to recent data collated by the Cellular Operators Association of India (COAI), three major mobile operators who account for 67 per cent of the sector revenues added 8.61 million rural customers combined in the first two months of 2013. This increase is subsequent to mobile phone companies tweaking distribution models and more importantly, providing customised data plans in villages.

Many companies who target rural areas through the use of mobile phones have started adopting innovative ways to reach out to their rural customers. India currently has several different information sharing products through which farmers can easily access information on various areas such as agricultural best practices, weather and market pricing using SMS, IVR or call centres.

Additionally, innovative services such as the missed call model are being used as communication mechanisms. This service has been used for seeking prompt solutions to addressing citizen grievances. Rural citizens have been connecting to utilities assigned for a number of sectors ranging from governance to education, social to cultural issues as well as entertainment.

Mobile today is also being used for addressing grave social concerns in rural areas. As per a recent Deloitte report on telecommunication prediction, through the National Rural Health Mission (NRHM) the government leveraged the use of mobile phones as part of their efforts to reduce maternal mortality rates by 43 per cent.

A few challenges that companies face today in addressing the rural population would be remote locations that are widespread,

inability to use SMS due to language limitation and low-end feature phones.

The increasing popularity of mobile phones encourages companies to use mobile marketing as a tool to acquire new customers, increase brand awareness, improve customer loyalty and the like.

Voice based campaign for the rural mobile user

The following is an example of a rural mobile marketing campaign conducted by IMImobile. The campaign showcases the effective usage of mobile as a medium to reach out to its rural customers. The mobile marketing campaign was conducted for one of the leading tractor manufacturers in India.

Problem: A leading tractor manufacturer wanted to create awareness about free tractor service camps that were being organised across various regions in rural India. The idea was to get existing customers to visit the service camp as well as encourage purchase of spare parts at the service camp.

Solution: The tractor manufacturer decided to create voice-based campaigns in different languages to reach out to their farmer customers. The campaigns were developed mainly to cater to areas of servicing and sales. The reaction of the rural customers to these voice campaigns was also studied post the implementation of the same.

The campaigns played to the rural consumers contained information on the following:

- Details on the free service camp organised by the particular retailer in the area for tractor servicing
- Venue, date, time and contact number
- Offers at the service camps such as discounts on spare parts and other exchange schemes
- Incentives such as free diesel, refreshments and other gifts for the customers who attend the service camps

We conducted an analysis over a sample set of 250 such voice campaigns played in different languages over a period of over six months (the duration of these campaigns). These voice clips ranged from as small as 10 seconds to as long as 60 seconds. The voice campaigns played were analysed to study the success rate.

Results

Overall: Out of a random sample set of more than half million voice outbound calls made, nearly two thirds were answered by the consumer. The drop rate of the calls depended majorly on the type of the campaigns that were played.